

Focus Group Codebook

1 st -level Codes	2 nd level codes	3 rd level codes	Example
Authenticity			
	Criteria		
		Believable content (content-level credibility)	P10: The content feels believable to me, because you can probably find similar examples in many parts of China, especially movements initiated by students.
		Detail, texture, and concrete evidence	P8: Compared to the interviews, the simulated conversations lack texture. I think it needs to be related to the details. For example, one mentioned red armbands and big-character posters. Those details feel like evidence to me. If they match historical photos or what I already know, then the story feels believable.
		Character differentiation in speech (tone/dialect)	P9: The tones and dialects should be at least a little different between characters.
		Demographic grounding for personas	P7: I was imagining their age, gender, where they're from, and how old they are.
		Human presence (sense of a real person behind the words)	P16: I want to feel that the information is coming from a real human being.
		Multimodal cues (facial expression, hesitations...)	P16: When I watch real interviews, it's easy for me to feel compassion and empathy because I can see body language, facial expressions, and hesitations. The AI agents, in contrast, speak too fluently, like actors reading lines, without pauses, repetitions, or other natural imperfections that come when someone recalls emotional memories.

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		Natural disfluency (pauses, hesitations, imperfections)	P4: I think adding more hesitations and pauses, and even some imperfect wording, would make the conversation feel more authentic.
		Empathic responsiveness (or lack of it)	P7: To be honest, I don't feel like they're responding with empathy. It doesn't feel human.
		Tone and delivery (scriptedness and emotional alignment)	P3: It's not only about the content, but also about how the content is delivered to the audience. The delivery felt like they were reading from a script.
		Historically appropriate vocabulary	P9: "Shame" doesn't feel like a word they would use.
		Voice and audio quality	P11: Those voices helped shape the personas. They conveyed something very similar to what I heard in the original videos. In that sense, it felt authentic. I think the voice in the simulation is natural enough.
	Why or why not		
		Content aligns with prior knowledge	P5: The content felt historically believable to me. A lot of the narrative matched my pre-existing knowledge about the Cultural Revolution, so I could understand the personal dimensions, like the frustration and regret one agent expressed over his life.
		AI habit: ends with a question	P8: When I use conversational AI, it often ends with a question as the last line, like "What about you?" or "How do you feel about it?" When that line appeared here, I felt like I was hearing AI talking to AI, not a real person.
		Role-consistent content	P1: I didn't feel the conversation was out of character because I read the brief description before each video, and what they said fit their

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			roles and identities during the Cultural Revolution.
		Multiple-role perspectives add plausibility	P1: It also gave us different perspectives from different roles during the Cultural Revolution period, which made it feel more plausible to me.
		Concrete personal detail strengthens plausibility	P5: The personal descriptions were helpful. For example, when an agent mentioned having a “black background” during the Cultural Revolution, that’s a significant detail. Because I already know the historical context, I could immediately understand why he would respond in that way. What he said matched my expectations, so I could connect to it quickly. That really mattered.
		Lack of vivid detail	P4: There are fewer vivid, concrete memories about participating in the Cultural Revolution. I admit that in these dialogues, there’s a lack of detail compared to what we saw in the fuller interviews.
		Lack of texture / no surprise	P14: Because I’ve seen the fuller interviews, the issue with the simulated conversations is that nothing feels anachronistic or surprising. Everything aligns with my understanding of the time period and how people in different roles would talk, but compared to the interviews, the simulations lack texture. History is complicated and sometimes hard to describe, but in the AI-generated conversations, it feels simplified, which reduces the realism for me.
		Need more details to reinforce authenticity	P10: I feel the authenticity would be more reinforced if more details could come up for all of the characters.
		Interpretive layer creates different authenticity	P12: The responses in the simulations feel different because there’s an added layer of interpretation or deduction, like drawing lessons from personal experiences. That extra

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			layer creates a different kind of authenticity, because it wasn't part of the original raw material.
		Fictional lines	P3: Some of the lines feel kind of fictional, like they were made up rather than grounded in the original material.
		Too American	P14: When the interviewer said something like, "Oh, I'm sorry to hear that. I know it was a very hard time for you," that response felt very American to me.
		Out-of-era/culture speech	P1: What feels missing is the tone and the linguistic realism. For example, according to historical studies, Red Guards had their own vocabulary and ways of speaking. Sometimes the dialogue also feels too ideological or moralizing. When we talk about the Cultural Revolution today, we may be driven by the value that it was wrong, but the conversation here feels overly shaped by that stance.
		Over-polished English delivery (formal/educational)	P15: The ending reflective sections in both videos felt a bit out of character. They were beautifully spoken, almost too beautifully. Very few people are that succinct and well-phrased in such a short time, so that lowered the authenticity for me.
		Too perfect English for the character's education/history	P17: My critique is that if these are supposed to be Red Guards, they shouldn't be speaking perfect English. If they spoke Mandarin, especially with a strong regional accent, that would feel more authentic. Many Red Guards at that time were illiterate or had limited formal education. I don't think they could organize themselves to speak so fluently in English, sometimes even better than me. That aspect makes it feel less realistic.
		Unnaturally smooth / no	P6: Both types of people would have to pause and remember things, right? But in these dialogues, everything flows super smoothly.

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		searching for words	
		Fixed turn-taking pattern	P17: Right now, the pattern is always fixed: the Red Guard speaks, then the victim speaks, then another participant.
		Low conversational realism (audiobook/podcast feel)	P4: It feels less like people interacting within a conversation and more like listening to an audiobook.
		Repetitive/low engagement	P5: It felt a little repetitive, and I wasn't really engaging with the characters. Maybe it's the images, or maybe the conversations were basically repeating themselves.
		Realistic images	P4: The people in the images looked very realistic. Almost real, I would say. Especially the emotions they conveyed really connected with those. I felt it was quite authentic.
		Resistance to non-human agents	P16: I find myself resisting the presence of these AI-generated images, reminding myself that these agents are not human and questioning whether they can truly feel anything.
		Simplicity of a historical narrative may reduce realism	P4: It's kind of always buried in some events. It's very complicated. It's hard to describe sometimes, but when it comes to the AI-generated conversations, it makes history simple.
		Too ideological or moralizing in tone	P4: They are kind of criticizing this historical time, so I feel like it's too ideological. I don't know why... We are kind of driven by a value that it is wrong.
		Voice resemblance to originals	P11: Those voices helped shape the personas. They really conveyed something very similar to what I heard in the original videos.

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Education			
	Benefits		
		A more interesting format for learning history	P9: It could be included in a course for students who want to learn more, as a more interesting way to engage with this history.
		Cost-efficient introduction to unfamiliar history	P8: I think these are great materials for people who are unfamiliar with the Cultural Revolution. This interactive dialogue format is easier to follow than textual information. It could also help people understand the relationships between different roles in a specific historical period, which can lead to a deeper understanding.
		Encourages critical comparison across sources	P10: These materials can be used to ask students to critically examine what they've seen across different sources. For example, they could compare the dialogue with films like To Live (Huozhe), which includes a significant portion related to the Cultural Revolution, and discuss what overlaps or differs.
		Helps students stay focused with short, classroom-friendly segments	P15: You might not convince a 19-year-old from Kansas to sit for 30 minutes and watch interview videos, but for 10 minutes in a classroom, with this on screen, it's a good way to deliver synthesized information while still conveying the idea that these were real people with real experiences.
		Helps learners connect emotionally and ethically to historical content	P7: People want to understand humanity. Even if the person represented is no longer alive, simulated stories might help people connect to the content.
		Interactive and dynamic learning increases engagement	P11: An interactive, dynamic format would make it feel more personal and more educational.

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		Multiple perspectives enrich understanding	P16: I think it's good for learners to hear each perspective. Because we have different personas and they tell their stories in their own way, having multiple perspectives to describe the same historical moment is helpful.
		Supplementary resource for undergraduate survey courses	P9: It could work as supplementary material for an undergraduate introductory history course, especially for students who want to get a rough understanding of that era.
		Visual support for public education and outreach	P4: I think the visual component would be helpful for teaching the public what the Cultural Revolution is.
		Vivid historical imagination through visuals and material details	P4: It gave us a very concrete picture of what people might have looked like during that time, which feels vivid. The background images and descriptions can also depict the settings and living conditions in those stories. For audiences who aren't familiar with China or its regions, that would be very helpful for understanding the place and the material conditions of that period.
	Risks and concerns		
		Concerns for historical reliability in sensitive historical contexts	P13: What concerns me is that on some platforms, you can already see events being distorted through AI-generated reports. I think this raises another concern, especially when it comes to historical movements like the Cultural Revolution.
		Difficulty distinguishing real vs. AI-generated history	P8: I'm worried that if AI keeps learning and generating new things, it might twist the truth or produce fakes. How can ordinary people tell which content is real history and which is generated by AI?
		False sense of "clear" historical understanding	P10: It's possible that this could leave kids with the impression that everyone has a very clear

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			idea of how to approach reflecting on the Cultural Revolution.
		Risk of inaccurate portrayals without human review	P4: Even if you provide a lot of data, the content will still be generated by AI. I'm not sure whether you will review all the content again, and you also mentioned possibly having conversations with users. If users can interact, then you can't really control what the AI might say. Maybe in the future the technology will be advanced enough that you don't need to worry. It could be fun. But if the content is all generated and you won't review it, I'm not sure it's safe right now.
		Imposed reflection may limit students' own thinking	P2: We want kids to develop their own reflections, instead of us imposing reflections on them.
		Loss of ambiguity and historical complexity	P2: There are details and historical facts that are hidden, buried in the passage of time, and we just don't know them. That's part of why we always want to come back to this topic.
		Merging multiple experiences into one character can mislead learners	P13: If you combine different people's experiences into one person, someone who doesn't know this history at all might think all those tragedies happened to a single individual.
		Misleading for those unfamiliar with history	P16: It can be misleading, especially for people who aren't familiar with the history, if they encounter AI-generated content first. That's one of my concerns about generated materials.
		Not suitable as a standalone learning tool	P9: It's not a good idea for people who have zero knowledge of that era to use this as their main way to learn.
		Privacy and data use risks	P7: If this is used in educational settings and people are interacting with AI, there's a risk that data could be captured, especially if the AI is simulating individuals who were once real

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			people or if students start sharing personal thoughts during the interaction.
		Risk of becoming emotionally indifferent to real suffering	P16: I worry that people might become indifferent after hearing real, touching, or painful memories shared by others.
		Students may dismiss AI-generated content	P15: I worry that many students don't take AI seriously. If they see something that is AI-generated, they might immediately think, "That's not real, so I don't need to care," which is ironic given how many people use AI for homework without questioning it.
	Suggestions		
		Add AI disclaimer	P15: I think adding a disclaimer would help. A disclaimer could clarify that this is AI-generated but curated by experts, vetted for accuracy, and meant to synthesize perspectives rather than recreate a single person's exact words.
		Add reflective prompting questions	P11: Another idea I had, based on what we discussed, is adding prompting questions to a quiz, like reflective questions. For example, what perspective stood out to you? What did you connect with? These prompts could relate to your teaching goals and help check whether students actually watched and understood the content.
		Collect user feedback after interaction	P7: There should be a quick survey or feedback prompt after students interact with the simulation, so they can leave comments or suggestions for improvement, especially in an educational setting.
		Combine with VR/AR to strengthen learning environment	P9: There should be a consent form to sign before conducting a survey or an interview, or some kind of ethical warning or disclaimer about responsibility.

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		Provide consent and ethical warning for participation	P9: We should have a consent form for participants to sign before we conduct a survey, an interview, or anything like that. There should also be some kind of warning or disclaimer about responsibility.
		For beginners, use real history sources first	P16: For people who aren't familiar with this history, it might still be better to read oral history books or watch documentaries or movies first. There are some very good oral history books from that period.
		Guide students in interpreting narratives across perspectives	P11: Because different scholars offer different perspectives, it would help to guide students on how to read and interpret these narratives.
		Add interactive elements for real-time questions and contextual answers	P7: In the middle of a conversation, the viewer could ask a question and the AI could respond with new historical details that fit the context. That would make it feel more personal and more educational. If I had a question, I'd want to ask it directly and get a thoughtful response from the persona.
		Indicate primary sources behind personas in metadata	P12: It would be helpful to include the sources of the raw materials in the metadata as well, because some instructors may want to bring these simulated conversations into the classroom.
		Provide scholarly background	P11: Maybe we could add scholarly background, like books and academic arguments about why this happened and how scholars interpret it. I like the idea of adding background information. I think it's very important, especially for students who are unfamiliar with this topic.
		Use shorter, segmented videos to support attention	P11: For students, short videos, like three minutes, are easier to focus on. If a video is ten minutes long, they might not stay focused, especially outside the classroom. So breaking

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			it into smaller segments could help keep their attention.
		Use AI dialogues after introducing real content	P6: Based on the authenticity scores, this content feels less credible than real interviews or real-life recordings. So after showing students something real, like interviews or documentary footage, you could introduce the AI-generated dialogues.
		Use as introductory content	P5: I think it's okay if it's used as introductory content, like: "What is the Cultural Revolution?" or "When did it happen?" In that case, AI could be used to summarize basic information.
		Use as pre-class material for modern Chinese/East Asian history	P10: It could be convenient to use this kind of material as pre-class content for a modern Chinese history or modern East Asian history course. If I were the instructor, I might assign it as a pre-class viewing or reading.
Emotional response			
		AI dialogues lacked emotional honesty	P6: In the AI dialogues, they were speaking objectively and generally, not in a way that felt personal. So it didn't feel completely open or emotionally honest.
		AI expresses emotions more directly than real interviews	P8: I empathized most with the victim and also with the Red Guard in the second video because they expressed their thoughts very clearly and directly. This was quite different from real-person interviews. When people talk about bad memories, they often avoid expressing their emotions directly and focus more on facts. But in the AI-powered simulation, the agents spoke about emotions openly.
		Knowing it's AI-generated reduces	P16: Knowing the dialogue was AI-generated made it harder for me to feel empathy and compassion.

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		emotional engagement	
		Comparing with real testimonies reduces emotional impact	P4: I've read some oral history books and watched some movies, and those felt more real to me. I was moved more by people's real experiences.
		Concern about historical reliability affects emotional response	P13: I didn't really feel shocked by those stories because they were very similar to what I had already heard, especially when you've done some research on that period. Yes, I'm concerned about how historically reliable this is.
		Curiosity about whether such dialogue is possible in real life	P12: While watching these artificial conversations between people on opposing sides during the Cultural Revolution, I kept wondering: Is this kind of conversation possible in real life?
		Judgment depends on prior knowledge; lack of knowledge makes trust difficult	P11: If I didn't already know about the Cultural Revolution or about people's personal experiences, I might not be able to trust these dialogues as easily.
		Disappointment at superficial interactions	P8: I was a little upset because I didn't think the interactions went deep enough. Personally, I expected more conflict, debate, or argument, but the exchanges between the three agents felt very superficial.
		Simulation mechanics disrupt emotional flow	P16: One thing that surprised or upset me was how agents would pose a question to the next speaker. Since each was speaking from a different perspective, some of these questions felt abrupt, almost out of the blue. I know this is how you keep the discussion moving in a simulation, but in a real situation, I'm not sure the participants could understand each other well enough to have such smooth exchanges.

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		Emotional content needs a conversational context and buildup	P7: It felt like there was emotional damage tied to the historical event. But when you're just listening, and a character says something intense out of nowhere, without anyone else caring or responding, it doesn't work. There needs to be a conversation first, and then you can build up to disclosure. That's how it works in real life.
		Familiar synthetic voice reduces emotional engagement	P10: I felt like I'd heard that man's voice many times before in different situations, and that familiarity made it harder for me to connect emotionally.
		Lack of emotional engagement when listening	P7: I had a different emotional response compared to listening. For example, when I was listening, I didn't feel anything. But when I was reading, I did feel something.
		Lacked immersion; felt distant and not engaging	P5: I think I would have felt much more immersed if it had been presented differently. I expected something more engaging, but this version felt very distant.
		Monologue style reduces emotional variation	P5: The videos are very short and typically only feature one agent speaking in a flat, monologue-style way, which reduced emotional variation for me.
		Original videos were more emotionally impactful	P6: Original videos were more emotionally impactful
		Overly open disclosure feels unnatural	P7: The characters were super open. It felt like someone was immediately disclosing all their feelings to a stranger.
		Perspective shift was engaging	P12: I found it very engaging, especially because of the perspective shift they offered.
		Politically correct and standardized	P10: It felt very politically correct and like a standard answer. I didn't find it very emotional.

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		answers feel emotionally flat	I just thought, “Okay, this is the standard answer.”
		Q&A format increased engagement	P6: Because the Q&A format involved someone asking questions and another person answering, it made me more engaged. Even though I wasn’t the one asking, it still made me curious about the historical background.
		Seeing real people on screen would increase emotional connection	P5: If we could see real people on screen, it would feel more immersive and make it easier to connect emotionally. In real interview videos, there are many types of interaction, not just depth of content but also variation in tone, emotion, and flow.
		Sadness	P11: First, it was sad. I also felt sad while listening, especially to the people who had real-life experiences. It really hit me emotionally.
		Shock and worry about AI’s power and future knowledge construction	P14: I still felt a bit shocked and also worried about our future. Even now, AI can create stories that sound like they actually happened and sound like they’re from a real person.
		Surprise at the civility of dialogue	P15: I was surprised that everyone was so cordial, almost upbeat, and hopeful. But knowing the dialogue was AI-generated definitely took away my emotional response. I kept thinking back to the original videos instead.
		Synthetic voice quality disrupts immersion	P16: Machine-automated sound that really affects my emotions a lot. Uh, when I listen to those.
		Tone too neutral and standardized	P5: In terms of the interaction itself, I felt the tone was too neutral, and the frequent, overly standardized English made the interaction feel less emotional.
		Too many characters made	P9: I think the conversation went in circles, and the characters kind of blended together. That

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		the emotional connection harder	made it harder for me to form an emotional connection.
General reflections before answering questions			
		Doubts about AI capturing individual variability	P4: I'm more interested in how regional features might show up later in AI-generated dialogue, and whether the system can pick up that someone is from a particular place.
		Difficulty synthesizing diverse narratives	P16: Even though all the videos are under the same topic, you can tell the narratives and subtopics vary widely. As a qualitative researcher, I feel a bit panicked when faced with a dataset with such a broad range of experiences that it's hard to bring them together into a single story.
		Generational differences in perspective	P2: You know, interviewees from different generations seem to respond differently.
		Accent-related comprehension difficulty	P14: But his accent made it a little hard to understand. He had a very strong dialect, so by the end of the video, I was a bit lost. I wasn't sure what message he was trying to deliver.
		Perceived fading of personal/historical memory	P13: The second interviewee was relatively young. I could feel that her memory of the past had faded. At my age, I still feel like I can serve as a bridge between the past and the present.
		The impact of the Cultural Revolution on the life course varies	P15: It was interesting to see how some people felt the Cultural Revolution affected the rest of their lives, while others seemed to feel they lived through it but didn't emphasize how it connected to their current lives.

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		Interest in cross-lingual representation (Chinese to English)	P2: I'm interested in exploring how we can work with this material in English, and what gets changed or lost when the language shifts.
		Emotional response: sorrow	P13: His story felt sorrowful to me. I felt a lot of sorrow from it.
		Fear of historical recurrence (echoes of the Cultural Revolution today)	P14: Overall, I did feel really bad, because the kind of disorder that happened during the Cultural Revolution, politics and culture pushing people in a bloody direction, feels like some of that is still happening in our society today.
		Surprise at positive childhood memories amid political chaos	P11: I was surprised when they said that children were happiest during that time compared to children today. That surprised me because I always thought children today were happier. In the past, they experienced political chaos, so I assumed they wouldn't have been that happy, but it seems more complicated than I expected.
Initial Reactions to AI-generated Historical Dialogue			
		concerns about accuracy and credibility	P1: I think it depends. Maybe the quality will improve over time, but for now, based on my past experience, I feel that in many cases the output still needs substantial improvement and checking.
		Creative recombination (rearranging historical information)	P2: It's like recruiting and rearranging historical messages or information.
		Potential to generate new	P2: That could lead to new dialogue or new connections among historical information,

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		insights or connections	including connections that have been hidden from us so far.
		Simulating historical figures' voices through dialogue	P2: Having historical figures "talk" with each other, based on what we put into the model about their intellectual contributions and life experiences. Then, seeing what those connections between their ideas might reveal through the dialogue. It's kind of my imagination of what this could mean.
Original video comments			
		Familiarity: content encountered elsewhere	P16: In those videos, the scenes and descriptions felt familiar to me. I feel like I've encountered similar content before, in books or movies.
		Gratitude for access to lived experiences	P9: I feel grateful that I have this opportunity to listen and learn about real events that happened to specific individuals.
		Easy comprehension (Mandarin)	P9: They speak in Mandarin, which makes it easy for me to understand what they mean.
Simulation vs. Original			
		Efficient synthesis of multiple testimonies	P1: With the simulation, you can gain a lot of information from just one dialogue because it combines and summarizes many things. It helps you learn more in a shorter period of time.
		Motivates further interest in original sources	P1: However, it also makes me want to know more about what the real people say in the original archive.
		Anonymity protection for sensitive historical topics	P4: What the simulation did very well was protect anonymity. The Cultural Revolution is a sensitive period, and even if participants in the videos choose not to show their faces or slightly change their voices, there are still

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			technological ways to identify them. With AI, we can mix personal information and generate a fictional identity, which reduces the risk of detection.